

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



The Leo High School choir practices at the school on Chicago's South Side on July 10. AUDREY RICHARDSON/CHICAGO TRIBUNE PHOTOS

In the national spotlight

Chicago's Leo High School boys choir headed to 'America's Got Talent' quarterfinals

By Darcel Rockett
Chicago Tribune

Imagine heading out to pick up your father's medicine at the neighborhood CVS one day, only to be stopped by four strangers who ask: "Can I take a picture with you?"

That's what happened to Kriston Bell, 17. When approached, the Beverly resident asked if they knew him from somewhere. Their response: "From 'America's Got Talent.'" The admirers took pictures to share with their kids.

"I'm just walking into Chick-fil-A, next thing I hear is someone say, 'Ain't that the people from 'America's Got Talent?'" said Dolton resident Stephen Jackson, 17.

This is the new normal for members of Leo High School's choir after their performance on the 20th season of NBC's reality



LaDonna Hill, the choir director, leads the group during practice.

talent show aired June 10 — now that the melodic prowess of the 22 young men from the South Side Catholic school for boys has gone global.

And while its choir has stepped to the forefront as of late, Leo High School has been known as a place where young Black and brown men are nurtured to succeed. And

they do — from sports to academics.

"Since I have been at Leo, more than 90% of our graduates have gone on to college," Leo President Dan McGrath said.

On "America's Got Talent," the choir wowed all four judges and the audience with a resounding rendition of The Score's "Born for This." The team heads back to California in August to participate in the talent competition's quarterfinals.

Choir members were rehearsing for hours at the school every Thursday in July. If they advance after this round, the group will be closer to winning the \$1 million grand prize.

The choir had a certain amount of notoriety locally prior to "AGT" — from taking the stage at the Democratic National Convention

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Dems like tax change in Trump's 'big bill'

Outside all they oppose in the plan, increase in SALT deduction favored

By Dan Petrella
Chicago Tribune

Gov. JB Pritzker and his fellow Democrats have been unrelenting in their criticisms of the tax and spending plan President Donald Trump signed July 4.

But along with much-lambasted cuts to Medicaid, food assistance and education, the budget reconciliation plan Republicans pushed through Congress this summer includes a tax change that Democrats as well as some Republicans in high-tax blue states have backed for years.

The measure temporarily raises the limit on how much of their state and local tax bills taxpayers can deduct when filing their federal income tax returns. Boosting the cap on the so-called SALT deduction to \$40,000, from the previous \$10,000, and extending its expiration date for five years will largely benefit those at the upper end of the income scale. But it's also seen as especially beneficial in states such as Illinois that have high property taxes.

"I think raising it is a good thing for the state of Illinois, and I think more needs to be done to kind of alleviate the pain that the Trump administration is visiting on states across the country," Pritzker said last week at an unrelated event in Chicago. "This is one way in which pain can be alleviated. So it's a positive thing overall. Large states, highly populous states like ours, tend to benefit from the SALT deduction, so whatever is good for the state of Illinois, I'm for."

Supporting the higher limit puts Democrats, who've

Turn to Taxes, Page 6

US-EU deal heads off threat of trade war

Agreement calls for 15% tariff on most goods, Trump says

By Will Weissert
Associated Press

EDINBURGH, Scotland — The United States and the European Union agreed to a trade deal setting a 15% tariff on most goods, President Donald Trump announced Sunday, staving off for now higher import taxes on both sides that might have sent shock waves through economies around the globe.

The announcement came after Trump and European Commission chief Ursula von der Leyen met briefly at Trump's Turnberry golf course in Scotland. Their private meeting culminated months of bargaining, with the White House

deadline Friday nearing for imposing punishing tariffs on the 27-member EU.

"It was a very interesting negotiation. I think it's going to be great for both parties," Trump said. The agreement was "a good deal for everybody" and "a giant deal with lots of countries."

Von der Leyen said the deal "will bring stability, it will bring predictability that's very important for our businesses on both sides of the Atlantic."

Trump said the EU had agreed to buy \$750 billion worth of U.S. energy and invest \$600 billion more than it already is in America, as well as making a major purchase of military equipment.

"We are agreeing that the tariff straight across for automobiles and everything else will be a straight-across tariff

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Victor Gensini, Northern Illinois University meteorology professor and a lead scientist for a project studying hail formation, checks storm data during an operation June 3 south of Tipton, Oklahoma. CAROLYN KASTER/AP

State should expect damaging hail more often, storm researchers say

By Adriana Pérez
Chicago Tribune

During severe thunderstorms, rising air shoots icy pellets the size of Dippin' Dots ice cream into the bitter cold of upper atmospheric layers. There, supercooled water freezes onto the small particles to form hail, which then falls when it gets too heavy for the storm's upward draft.

As climate change warms average global temperatures, hailstones larger than pingpong or golf balls will become more frequent — likely worsening the weather hazard's already billions of dollars in annual property damage across the country, according to a study published last year in the scientific journal npj Climate and Atmospheric Science.

"Climate change is obviously

occurring," said Victor Gensini, a meteorologist and professor of atmospheric science at Northern Illinois University who led the study. "The question, for scientists, is often: How does that manifest itself (in) these smaller-scale extreme weather perils?"

Insurance companies have reported rising hail damage claims

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TODAY'S WEATHER



High 93 Low 75

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 12

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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